

Support After an Autopsy

The feelings that can come with this moment — and gentle, honest reassurance about each of them.

When someone you love has died, an autopsy can bring its own set of feelings on top of grief. Maybe you said yes to an autopsy during the hardest hours of your life. Maybe the law required one, and the decision was never yours to make. Either way, what you are feeling now is normal, and you are not alone in it.

Mixed feelings are common

In the days and weeks around an autopsy, many families tell us they feel:

- Unsure whether they made the right choice
- Anxious while waiting for results
- Uneasy about the examination itself
- Hopeful for answers, and afraid of them at the same time
- Relief, guilt, or numbness — sometimes all in one day

If you chose an autopsy, it may help to remember that the choice was an act of care. Answers can bring peace of mind, guide your family's future health, and help doctors care for other patients. If the medical examiner required the autopsy, that was the law's requirement — never a burden you chose, and not one you need to carry.

While you wait

- Funeral and memorial plans can almost always move forward; an autopsy rarely delays them and does not prevent a viewing.
- Results take time. Waiting is hard — you do not need to wait silently. You are always welcome to call us with a question.

- Lean on the people who love you, and let them carry some of the practical tasks.

When the results are ready

We will contact you, and we can walk through the findings with you in plain language. You are welcome to bring family or a written list of questions. Sometimes results give a clear answer; sometimes a partial one; and once in a while no single cause can be found. Any of these can stir grief up again — that reaction is normal, and support is available for it.

If the waiting becomes too heavy

If you have thoughts of harming yourself, or grief feels like more than you can survive, call or text **988** now (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, 24/7). For anything less urgent, your doctor or our chaplains are a good first call.

You can also explore our [grief & bereavement resources](#) for groups, reading, and support tailored to adults, children, and specific kinds of loss.

Developed by the Central Autopsy Service at Henry Ford Health. An initiative led by **Pamela Holmes-Hill** and **Troy Shaffer**. Website and content by **Omar Z. Baba, MD**.